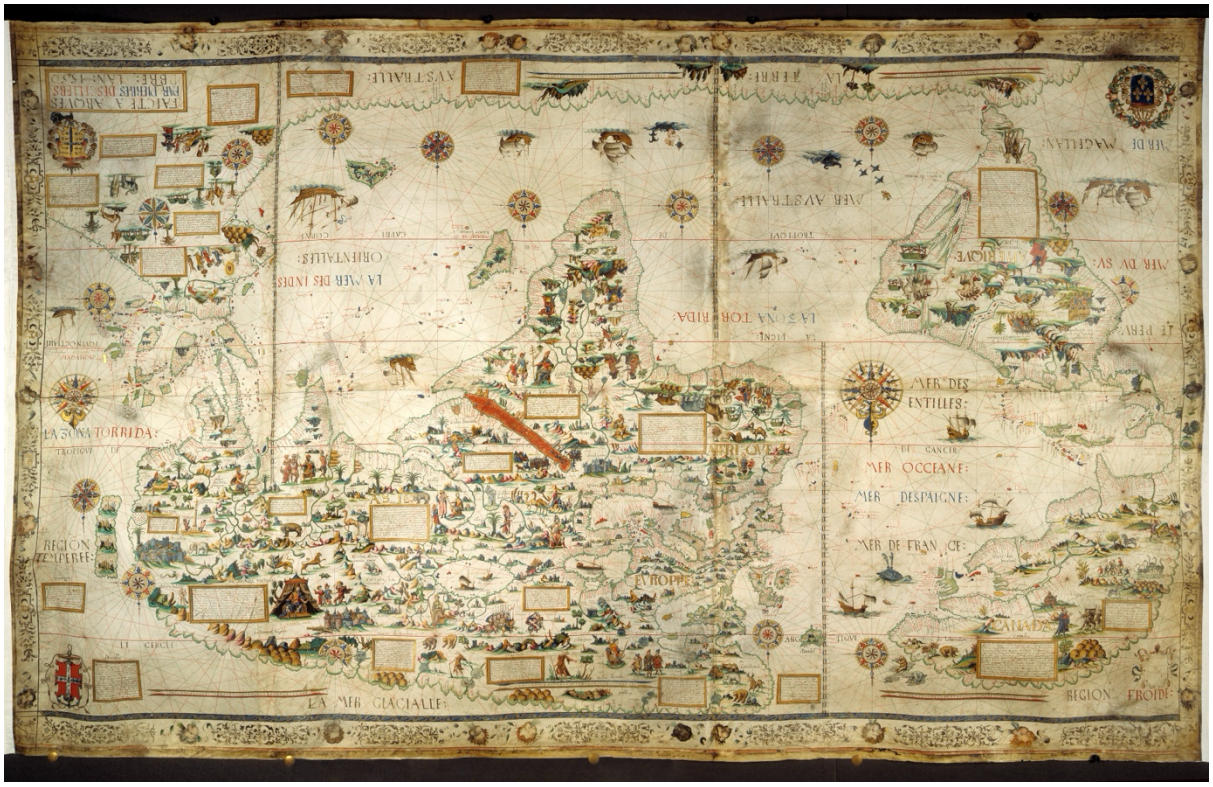
HIS 206.01: Introduction to Western European History
Fall 2026
Monday and Wednesday: 15.30 – 16.45
Rhyne Building 257



Pierre Desceliers *World Map* (1550)

Contact Information:
Instructor: Dr. Austin Collins
Office Hours: MW 13.00-13.30 Rhyne 232
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Course Description:
An introductory course to the some of the central themes in the history of Western Europe since 1600, including domesticity, Empire, political and industrial 'revolution', and more (3 Credit Hours).

Required Texts:
John Merriman, *A History of Modern Europe* (4th Edition)
Jeremy Popkin, *A Short History of the French Revolution*
Voltaire, *Candide* (1759)
Other articles and texts will be available on Canvas

Course Objectives/Learning Outcomes:

1. Investigate the "rebirth" of interest in classical art, literature, and culture, and the consequent innovations in all these areas of endeavor.
2. Comprehend how and why people's perception and definition of Christianity changed as a consequence of the various Protestant and Catholic reformations.
3. Understand European exploration and expansion into new territories: Africa, Asia, and the Americas
4. Delve into significant cultural, artistic, political and religious leaders of this period.
5. Become familiar with the major events that occurred before and during the French Revolution. The lectures and secondary sources will offer students context and factual grounding. The primary sources will allow students to have a first-hand experience of the period.
6. Grapple with the complex, and often contradictory, historical explanations that surround these events. We will compare and contrast the assumptions, approaches, and methodologies of various historians and critically examine the interpretations that they offer. We will not just reflect on the Revolution itself, but on the historiographical debates surrounding it.
7. Examine changes since the eighteenth century in European social, economic, cultural and political structures, locating Europe's place in world history and its development.
8. Provide an in-depth exploration of cultural, philosophical, and theological values and ideas of this period.
9. Skilfully interpret a variety of evidence from the past for credibility, position, and perspective.
10. Reason through unfamiliar concepts and ideas using tools appropriate to the discipline.

Course Policies:

- **Class Format:** The format of this class is **in-person**. Regular attendance and in-class participation are crucial for success.

- **Attendance:** At Lenoir-Rhyne University students are expected to attend all scheduled class sessions, participate fully in the learning process, engage respectfully with instructors and peers and complete all course requirements. Attendance is critical to a student's educational experience and to their learning. Thus, students are expected to attend every class meeting and attendance will be taken every class. After **two unexcused absences**, students will receive **10-point deduction** on their attendance grade in the course. If unexcused absences reach **more than 25% (6 sessions) of the class**, students will **receive a failing grade in the course**. Attendance/participation is worth 10% of your overall semester grade. Students with reasonable absences will be given consideration and opportunities for make-up work. Students with unreasonable absences will not receive such consideration. If you believe you will be absent for a future class, please alert the instructor so proper arrangements can be made. Reasonable absences include documented illness, deaths in the family and other documented crises, call to active military duty or jury duty, and official university activities. These absences will be accommodated in a way that does not arbitrarily penalize students who have a valid excuse.

- **Reading**: This course is a reading intensive course. Students are expected to have read each assignment by the assigned time. Students are especially encouraged to start early on the texts that require written assignments, particularly *A History of Modern Europe* and *A Short History of the French Revolution.*

- **Late Assignments**: Late assignments will not be accepted. The only exception to this policy is for students with valid, documented reasons. Unless otherwise announced, all assignments must be turned in digitally to Canvas; hard copies or copies submitted via email will not be accepted.

- **Politeness and Decorum**: Because the content of this course occasionally deals with controversial material, both the student and the instructor are expected to act in a **civil manner** when engaging in classroom discussion. In addition, students are asked to refrain from actions that distract others during class, i.e. talking, sleeping, texting, use of cell phones and laptops for non-class activities. Appropriate action will be taken for repeated violations of this politeness and decorum guideline.

Artificial Intelligence Statement:

There is NO legitimate use for AI programs such as ChatGPT in this course. If you need help with an assignment or for studying, do not hesitate to reach out to me. I am happy to help. Using such a program to facilitate any graded work in this course will be counted as cheating/plagiarism.

Lenoir-Rhyne Student Honor Commitment and Statement of Academic Integrity:

All students at Lenoir-Rhyne University are expected to know and agree to accept the following Lenoir-Rhyne University statement of academic integrity:

"a fundamental purpose of a liberal education is its attempt to cultivate in the student a sense of honor and high principles pertaining especially to academics, but extending to all areas of life. An inherent feature of Lenoir-Rhyne University is its commitment to an atmosphere of integrity and ethical conduct. As a student of Lenoir-Rhyne University, I accept as my personal responsibility the vigorous maintenance of honesty, truth, fairness, civility, and concern for others.

My devotion to integrity demands that i will not cheat in academic work and that I adhere to the established and required community code of conduct. I accept the responsibility for upholding the established standards against those who would violate them. And I understand and accept the consequences of infracting upon or assisting others in infracting upon this code. In addition to and beyond the requirements of any code or law, I affirm my own commitment to personal honor and integrity in all matters large and small. Even though the ideal of honor is an abstract one, by implementing this ideal, I join the Lenoir-Rhyne community in making the concept of honor a reality."

Information For Students with Disabilities:

Lenoir-Rhyne University does not discriminate on the basis of physical or mental disability in admission, treatment, and access to any educational programs and activities. Any student with a disability who is eligible for, or has questions regarding accommodations, should contact Avery Staley, Vice President of Diversity, Equity, & Inclusion at Avery.Staley@lr.edu or call at 828-328-7443 for questions.

Sex/Gender Non-Discrimination & Anti-Retaliation Policy Information:

Lenoir-Rhyne Policy, in addition to federal and state law (to include Title IX), prohibits discrimination and harassment on the basis of sex, sexual orientation, and gender identity in University programs and activities. Any student who is impacted by sexual harassment, sexual assault, domestic violence, dating violence, stalking, sexual exploitation, gender discrimination, pregnancy discrimination, gender-based harassment, or related retaliation should contact the University's Title IX Coordinator to make a report and/or access support and resources. The Title IX Coordinator can be reached at leah.reynolds@lr.edu or 828-328-7040.

You can access support and resources even if you do not want to take any further action. You will not be forced to file a formal complaint or police report. Please be aware that the University may act on its own if essential to protect the safety of the community. If you are interested in making a report, please use the Online Reporting/Referral Form. Please note that the University's ability to respond will be limited if you report anonymously.

Notice that Faculty are Responsible Employees with Mandatory Reporting Obligations All faculty members are considered Responsible Employees, per Lenoir-Rhyne's Sex/Gender Non-Discrimination and & Anti-Retaliation Policy. Faculty are therefore required to report all known information regarding alleged conduct that may be a violation of the Policy to the Title IX Coordinator, even if a student discloses an experience that occurred before attending Lenoir-Rhyne and/or an incident that only involves people not affiliated with Lenoir-Rhyne. Reports are required regardless of the amount of detail provided and even in instances where support has already been offered or received.

While faculty members want to encourage you to share information related to your life experiences through discussion and written work, students should understand that faculty are required to report past and present sexual harassment, sexual assault, domestic and dating violence, stalking, and gender discrimination that is shared with them to the Title IX Coordinator so that the University can inform students of their rights, resources, and support. While you are encouraged to do so, you are not obligated to respond to outreach conducted because of a report to the Title IX Coordinator.

If you need to speak with someone in confidence, who does not have an obligation to report to the Title IX Coordinator, Lenoir-Rhyne has several Confidential Resources available to support you:

Hickory Campus: Cornerstone Student Support and Wellness Center; 8th Avenue behind Fritz-Conrad; 828-328-7959 Health Services; 625 7th Ave NE, Hickory, NC 28601; 828-328-7958; University Pastor: 828-781-1110

Hate, Bias, Discrimination, and Harassment

Lenoir-Rhyne values safety, cultural and ethnic diversity, social responsibility, lifelong learning, equity, and civic engagement.

Consistent with these principles, Lenoir-Rhyne prohibits discrimination and harassment in its educational programs and activities or with respect to employment terms and conditions based on race, creed, color, religion, sex, gender, pregnancy, ancestry, age, gender identity or expression, national origin, veterans' status, marital status, sexual orientation, physical or mental disability, or genetic information.

Students (and faculty and staff) who experience discrimination, harassment, hate, or bias based upon a protected status or who have such matters reported to them should report to the Vice President for Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion. You may report incidents that happen to you anonymously. Please note that the University's ability to respond may be limited if you report anonymously.

Institutional Policies for Syllabi

Syllabus Change Policy:

Except for changes that substantially affect implementation of the evaluation (grading) statement, this syllabus is a guide for the course and is subject to change with advanced notice. Any changes will be publicly announced, either in class or via the course website.

Grading/Evaluation:

The course grade is composed of the following components and based on the following scale**:**

- **Research Paper (35% of total grade):** This 10-page paper will count as the major assignment of the course. Students will research and write on any aspect of course, as long as the self-posing question can be answered with an analytical thesis statement supported by a formidable structure. More details will be discussed in due course.
- **Outline & Thesis (15 % of total grade):** A milestone assignment in preparation of the major research paper.
- **Research Questions & Bibliography (10% of total grade):** A milestone assignment in preparation of the major research paper.
- **Proposal (5% of total grade):** An initial assignment designed to begin initial development towards the major research paper.
- **Story Map Group Presentation (25% of total grade):** The presentational assignment this semester will be the creation of a story map about a person, event, institution, or other concept discussed in our course this semester. To complete this assignment students in groups of two or three will learn to use the application StoryMap.JS. This narrative will allow students to demonstrate their understanding of the core concepts covered in class, and apply their knowledge gained in our class discussions. This assignment is effectively the final exam, as the 15-minute presentation will be given during the assigned final exam time slot.
- **Participation (10% of total grade):** Active participation (asking questions, participating in discussions, active attention, regular attendance, etc.) in seminars and reading the material will be expected.

Grading Scale: A (100–93) / A- (92.9–90) / B+ (89.9–87) / B (86.9–83) / B- (82.9–80) / C+ (79.9–77) / C (76.9–73) / C- (72.9–70) / D+ (69.9–67) / D (69.9–63) / D- (62.9–60) / F (59.9–0)

Course Content, Outline, Readings, and Assignments:

Class	Date	Topic	Reading*	Assignment
1	24 August	Introduction & Syllabus		
I. Early Modern Europe				
2	26 August	Renaissance	HME, Ch. 2	
3	31 August	Reformation & Counter-Reformation	HME, Ch. 3	
4	2 September	Wars of Religion	Davis, Natalie Zemon, 'The Rites of Violence: Religious Riot in Sixteenth-Century France' *Past & Present* 59 (1973), pp. 51-91.	
Labor Day	7 September			
5	9 September	Witchcraft & Magic	Roper, Lyndal, 'Witchcraft and Fantasy in Early Modern Germany', *History Workshop* 32 (1991), pp. 19-43.	
6	14 September	Age of Connections	HME, Chs. 5-6	
7	16 September	Global Religious Conversion	Sandberg, Brian, 'Beyond Encounters: Religion, Ethnicity and Violence in the Early Modern Atlantic World, 1472-1700', *The Journal of World History* 17 (2006), pp. 1-25.	**Topic Proposal**
8	21 September	Enlightenment	HME, Ch. 9	
9	23 September	Absolutism & *Candide*	Voltaire, *Candide* (1759)	
II. French Revolution & Napoleon				
10	28 September	Origins of the French Revolution	SHFR, Ch. 1	
11	30 September	Collapse of the Bourbon	SHFR, Ch. 2	**Research Questions & Bibliography**
Fall Break	5 October			
12	7 October	Revolutionary Rupture, 1789-1790	SHFR, Ch. 3	
13	12 October	The Defeat of the Liberal Revolution, 1790-1792	SHFR, Ch. 4	
14	14 October	The Convention and the Radical Republic, 1792-1794	SHFR, Ch. 5	
15	19 October	The Return to Order, 1794-1799	SHFR, Ch. 6	**Outline & Thesis**

16	21 October	The Napoleonic Consulate, 1799-1804	SHFR, Ch. 7	
17	26 October	Napoleonic Empire, 1804-1805	SHFR, Ch. 8	
18	28 October	Congress of Vienna & The Restoration	HME, Ch. 15, 'Intro', 'The Post-Napoleonic Settlement', 'Restoration Europe'	
19	2 November	**Writing Workshop**		
III. Modern Europe				
20	4 November	Romanticism	HME, Ch. 15, 'Romanticism'	
21	9 November	Industrialization	HME, Ch. 14	
22	11 November	1848 Revolutions	HME, Ch. 16	
23	16 November	Beaux Arts & Impressionism	HME, Ch. 20, 'Cultural Ferment'	**Research Paper**
24	18 November	Italian & German Unifications	HME, Ch. 17	
25	23 November	Imperialism	HME, Ch. 21	
Thanksgiving	25 November			
26	30 November	Nationalism	HME, Ch. 18	
27	2 December	**Story Map Workshop**		
Final Exam	9 December	17.00-19.30	**Group Presentation**	

*HME: *History of Modern Europe*; SHFR: *A Short History of the French Revolution*